Cold Storage

By Ronald Ribman

(LANDAU takes a bite of a candy bar which is stale and tastes bad, he tries to re-wrap it and looks for a place to throw it away)

PARMIGIAN: You're squashing it. You're squashing it!

LANDAU: What?

PARMIGIAN: If ya don't want it give it to me! (pause) There's no point in squashing something just because you don't want it! What are you saving it for Halloween?

LANDAU: I'll throw (the candy) it away later there's no garbage out here.

PARMIGIAN: Don't throw it away later. Throw it away now. What are you in for anyway?

LANDAU: Exploratory surgery.

PARMIGIAN: Oh yeah? What are they exploring for? Cancer? (laugh)

LANDAU: It was just a shadow on an x-ray of my stomach, a few cells they weren't quite sure about.

PARMIGIAN: Sure

LANDAU: Really just a small twinge. I don't even feel it anymore.

PARMIGIAN: Whatta ya working on, Landau?

LANDAU: I don't understand

PARMIGIAN: Sure you understand. What are you working on? An ulcer? Is that what you're working on for yourself? I told them I had a tickle in the throat. Honest to God, that's what I thought I had. I came through the door and told them I had a tickle in my throat!

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(laughter stops) Take my word for it. On this floor, it's never a twinge in the stomach or tickle in the throat. You got what I got.

LANDAU: What's that?

PARMIGIAN: The big *C*.

INTRODUCTION

"You have cancer." The tragically-common, often literal death sentence no one wants to hear. What do you do? How do you respond to those life-threatening words? Chemotherapy, radiation? Humor or depression . . . denial? In Cold Storage by Ronald Ribman, we meet to men with very different responses to the diagnosis of cancer. Some see a hopeless end, while others see an endless hope.

PARMIGIAN: Yep, you're going down for the count, same as me.

LANDAU: On the contrary, Mr. Parmigian, I'm just here for exploratory surgery.

PARMIGIAN: Sure, and you're all dressed up in your Bloomingdales pajamas. You look…. Spiffy

LANDAU: Thank you.

PARMIGIAN: You know what I weighed six months ago? 252 pounds. I looked spiffy too. I was the King Kong of the fruit and vegetable business. I had a fist like two hammocks. Now I can't even find them anymore. I tell 'em my clothing don't fit me anymore, they tell me the hospital laundry must be stretching them out. Can you believe such a pack of crap? You have to be a moron to believe something like that. What did you used to do for a living?

LANDAU: I didn't *used* to do anything Mr. Parmigian, I'm still doing it. I'm an investment advisor in fine art.

PARMIGIAN: Oh yeah? What the hell's an investment advisor in fine art?

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LANDAU: I recommend investment purchases in fine art to investors interested in capital appreciation. I generally handle accounts in European glass and Chinese ceramics.

PARMIGIAN: Hey that's terrific, that's really terrific…. Listen, Do you have any recommendations for long term growth? (he laughs – starts to cough bad).

LANDAU: Are you all right, Mr. Parmigian? Mr. Parmigian. (When he doesn't answer him, Landau starts to get nervous) I'll get a nurse. I'll be right back.

PARMIGIAN: (grabbing his arm) Don't bother. (tries to gets breath back)

LANDAU: Are you sure?

PARMIGIAN: Yes, I'm sure! I'm sure! It only hurts when I try and stay alive. When I make jokes and try to stay alive. Listen, you want to do me a favor?

LANDAU: If I can yes.

PARMIGIAN: Don't worry, it's just a little favor. Get behind me and push me off the roof.

LANDAU: What?

PARMIGIAN: I'd do it myself but I don't have the guts.

LANDAU: I really don't think you ought to joke about that.

PARMIGIAN: You think it's a joke? Come on be a sport, do it now and you'll be just in time for the six o'clock news. "Incredible man splatters to death on pavement in front of Hope Memorial Hospital." You'll be famous for five or six minutes.

LANDAU: I have no desire to be famous at the cost of somebody else's life.

PARMIGIAN: I'll make it interesting for you. As soon as you push me off the roof I'll go into a triple summersault fold up like a jack knife and

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do a swan dive through the entrance awning. You live another six months you won't see that again.

LANDAU: I'm not going to listen to this. I don't know whether you're joking or not but I'm not going to listen to this.

PARMIGIAN: Alright I'll do it myself.

LANDAU: No!

PARMIGIAN: Take your hand off me or I'll bite it off!

LANDAU: You're not going to bite anything off.

PARMIGIAN: I'm warning you. Aright, you win. I don't have the energy to fight with anybody. I want a Doctor Pepper. Go inside and get me a Doctor Pepper I'm thirsty.

LANDAU: Not now.

PARMIGIAN: What's the matter? It disturbs you?

LANDAU: Seeing somebody try to take their own life? Yes, it disturbs me. Nobody has the right to do something like that.

PARMIGIAN: Why not? Whose life is it?

LANDAU: That's not the point. The point is… Look they're coming up with something.

PARMIGIAN: They're coming up with nothing.

LANDAU: Don't say that. They're making fantastic progress all the time. Just last Sunday I read and article in The Times about how cockroaches can't get cancer.

PARMIGIAN: That's wonderful news if you're a cockroach.

LANDAU: That's not the point. If they can't give cockroaches cancer, maybe they can find out what it is that prevents cancer.

PARMIGIAN: You want to know what prevents cancer? Death! Death prevents cancer.

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LANDAU: Well, with that attitude you might as well just give up.

PARMIGIAN: I have. Push me off the roof.

LANDAU: Look, I can't handle this kind of thing right now! I just (catching himself then offering up hope of ending the conversation.) You're just depressed. Tomorrow you'll be glad you're still alive.

PARMIGIAN: No I won't.

LANDAU: Yes, you will, believe me.

PARMIGIAN: No, I won't, and why should I believe you?

LANDAU: Because people SURVIVE! They go on! They live. Nobody tries to commit suicide unless they're depressed.

PARMIGIAN: I happen to be in a very good mood Mr. Landau or hadn't you noticed? The sun is shining; the dogs are peeing all over the side walk. The best time to commit suicide is when you're in a good mood. I tried to commit suicide three times this month, and never once was I in a bad mood.

LANDAU: Why do you insist on involving me with this?

PARMIGIAN: To tell you the truth, the reason I asked you is that I don't have the courage myself. What I said about not having any guts is true, literally. They took out my bladder, shaved off my prostate, and tied my bowels to my hip bone. See… Now my urine flows with my blood, and when I shake my leg, my liver drips prostatic fluid on my shoes. And that's the good news. Want to hear some bad news? Last week I ran outta Blue Cross.

LANDAU: Oh, I'm sorry. It must be terrible watching your estate being destroyed by an illness.

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PARMIGIAN: It's not an estate; it's a fruit and vegetable business. It's always been my dream. I'll tell you what, Landau. You tell me your filthy dreams and I'll tell you mine.

LANDAU: I have no dreams that would interest anybody.

PARMIGIAN: You would be surprised at what interests me. The closer I get to death, the more everything interests me. Dreams other people throw out with the garbage I can spend a whole day living on.

LANDAU: I have no dreams of interest to anybody.

PARMIGIAN: What an absolutely marvelous quality of surface veneer you have, Mr. Landau.

LANDAU: If you're interested in surface veneer, perhaps I might show you something in a 19th century Chinese lacquer box. You might find it interesting to see how coat upon coat of lacquer can be laid down until the box itself may be removed leaving nothing behind but the form and the lacquer – the black, brilliant, slightly poisonous lacquer. (pause) I'm sorry to disappoint you, Mr. Parmigian, but there's nothing in me you're going to be able to live on. I've got nothing to give you.

PARMIGIAN: Nothing?

LANDAU: Nothing.

PARMIGIAN: All right, I'll accept that lie. There's no point in being too pushy the first ten minutes you meet somebody. First you should break the ice, so I'll give a riddle. What's shaped like a big green football with four legs and a tail?

LANDAU: How outrageous you are.

PARMIGIAN: Not the answer.

LANDAU: I don't know the answer.

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PARMIGIAN: A watermelon.

LANDAU: A watermelon doesn't have four legs and a tale!

PARMIGIAN: I lied. Where are you going?

LANDAU: I have an appointment down in the x-ray room this afternoon. I have to swallow something and they're going to x-ray it.

PARMIGIAN: That's a terrific test. You'll like it.

LANDAU: You had that test?

PARMIGIAN: Oh sure. That's one of the best procedures in the hospital.

LANDAU: I'll be home in a few days. Time enough to have a few friends over for dinner.

PARMIGIAN: Oh yea, that's right. You're just in for an exploratory. I forgot. Tell me something, Landau. You seem to be in pretty good physical shape. You do something?

LANDAU: I play squash a couple of afternoons a week, and on the weekends some tennis if I can get away.

PARMIGIAN: Listen, your cardiovascular system stays in good shape there's no reason why you couldn't go on living until this time next year.

LANDAU: I wish you'd stop doing that.

PARMIGIAN: Doing what?

LANDAU: Implying that there is something wrong with me.

PARMIGIAN: Was that what I was doing?

LANDAU: YES! THAT'S ENOUGH!

PARMIGIAN: If you don't like what I'm saying push me off the roof! You're a pretty violent man, Mr. Landau.

LANDAU: I'm not violent. You just irritated me, that's all. I hate violence.

PARMIGIAN: It doesn't pay to get irritated. You'll probably be out in two or three weeks.

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LANDAU: You think so?

PARMIGIAN: No.

LANDAU: What's the matter with you?

PARMIGIAN: That's pretty obvious isn't it?

LANDAU: I'm not talking about that. You don't seem to give an ounce of thought to what you're saying! You don't know anything about me!

PARMIGIAN: That's right.

LANDAU: You bet that's right so knock it off!

PARMIGIAN: I apologize.

LANDAU: All right let's just forget it.

PARMIGIAN: Oh, what a great liar you are.

LANDAU: What lie?

PARMIGIAN: Death is knocking on your door and still you persist in lying to yourself.

LANDAU: That's garbage! Absolute garbage!

PARMIGIAN: You deny it?

LANDAU: Yes of course I deny it!

PARMIGIAN: Naturally, of course.

LANDAU: What the hell is that supposed to mean!

PARMIGIAN: What's the matter I touched a nerve?

LANDAU: Forget it I don't have time for this.

PARMIGIAN: You got at least six months.

LANDAU: STOP IT! Talking to you! Trying to talk to you… it's… it's

PARMIGIAN: Absurd?

LANDAU: It's humiliating!

PARMIGIAN: Of course it's humiliating. You know why? Because the mind's a piece of garbage. It's never happy with what you do for it. I once

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took my mind down to Barbados for two weeks and you know what it said to me? "You should have taken us to Jamaica." The real reason Adam and Eve got thrown out of the Garden had nothing to do with fruit. Because there's nothing wrong with a piece of fruit. It's a good laxative. God finally got tired of waiting around for thanks from the human brain.

LANDAU: Oh god . . . I'm going inside now Mr. Parmigian. I have to go to x-ray.

PARMIGIAN: Landau?

LANDAU: Yes?

PARMIGIAN: I'll meet you out here tomorrow?

LANDAU: Okay.

PARMIGIAN: I promise you a very interesting day.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

Utah State Finalist

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